



THESSALONIKI GREECE

Dolmades in Thessaloniki

As a rule, Greek food is for purists and traditionalists, but Thessaloniki, the capital of Macedonia, is an exhilarating exception to the rule. Bridging East and West, Greece's second city has adapted to its cosmopolitan population over the centuries to develop a fusion of Middle Eastern and Balkan cuisine. Its signature dishes – such as dolmades (stuffed vine leaves) – are full of surprises.



Lying on the ancient trade route linking the Adriatic with Istanbul, Thessaloniki has long been a confluence of cultures. Echoes of its former occupants crop up all

over the city, in Roman ruins, Ottoman baths, crumbling synagogues, and Byzantine chapels. The city's eclectic cuisine also bears the hallmarks of all its past residents. But the most pervasive flavors are those left by the Ottoman empire, whose rule of Macedonia extended to 1913, almost a century after the rest of Greece was liberated.

Centuries of Ottoman occupation are most obvious today in the ramshackle Turkish quarter of Kastra, which is a 19th-century time warp. Minarets poke out among apartment buildings; former hammams (Turkish baths) are now cultural centers, movie theaters, or flower stands. Even the city's most prominent landmark, the White Tower (which isn't white at all), was built by the Ottomans as a fortress, before becoming a notorious prison. The tower is an evocative monument to the city's diversity, and has a fascinating virtual tour of its culinary history on the top floor.

Thessaloniki's thriving meze culture owes much to the influence of Asia Minor (the area that now

encompasses most of modern-day Turkey). Convivial meals consist of a succession of small dishes designed to be shared, usually accompanied by a glass of ouzo or *tsipouro*, spirits distilled from the vine. Grape leaves are also used to make one of the city's most popular meze dishes, dolmades, whose name reveals its origin: *dolma* is the Turkish word for "stuffed." These glossy little parcels are also known as *yaprakia*, from the Turkish *yaprak*, or leaf. The cooks of Thessaloniki have access to tender vine leaves from the fertile mountains of Macedonia, the source of northern Greece's robust red wines. The leaves are picked in late spring, blanched and preserved in brine, then rolled by hand.

Eating a dolma is like opening a gift – you never quite know what's inside until the first bite. Tightly wrapped into dainty bundles, they might be filled with minced lamb, currants, and pine nuts, spiced with cloves, cumin, or cinnamon, speckled with mint, dill, or parsley, or bursting at the seams with sardines, fennel, and onions. *Yalantzi* (Turkish for "fake") are meatless dolma; *sarmadakis* uses pickled cabbage leaves stuffed with minced lamb and smothered in *avgolemono*, a tangy egg and lemon sauce that is almost as tricky to perfect as mayonnaise. The variations are endless, and always delicious.

A Day in Thessaloniki

Layers of history intersect in Thessaloniki, Greece's most alluring city. With its high density of museums, waterfront bars, restaurants, and hip hotels, Thessaloniki also has a vibrant modern identity.

MORNING Visit the **Archaeological Museum**, a thrilling modernist building with an extraordinary collection of artifacts. Then wander along the boardwalk to the **Photography and Cinema museums**, formerly shipping warehouses. Head to the **Teloglion Foundation of Art**, a museum in a hilltop park with a great café, Art 02.

AFTERNOON Get lost in the twisting alleys of the old Turkish Quarter, ringed by Byzantine walls. Old-time *ouzeri* (meze bars) with overgrown courtyards are tucked among the timber-framed houses. Meals here are often accompanied by spontaneous renditions of *rembetika* – the Greek blues.

EVENING The party gets started around midnight; follow the crowds outside the bars on **Valaoritou Street** and around the splendid **Malakopi** arcade.

Essentials

GETTING THERE

Fly to **Macedonia International Airport**, then take **Bus 78** into town. Intercity trains from Athens's Larissis station take about 5 hours.

WHERE TO STAY

The Met (inexpensive) is a glossy newcomer with a destination Asian restaurant, spa, and rooftop pool. www.themethotel.gr

Excelsior (moderate) is a restored 1920s property with a fun bistro. www.excelsiorhotel.gr

Daïos (expensive) offers modern minimalism on the waterfront. www.daïoshotels.com

TOURIST INFORMATION

136 Tsimiski Street; www.saloniki.org

